

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

KERALA

BABUS' FALL FROM GRACE

By Jeemon Jacob

Bureaucrats in public spats are not a new phenomenon in Kerala, but this is the first time two IAS officers have been suspended for violating the Civil Service Code of Conduct. N. Prasanth, an IAS officer of the 2007 batch and special secretary to the agriculture department, was suspended for his public comments against A. Jayathilak, the additional chief secretary (ACS) for finance, on social media. The case against K. Gopalakrishnan, the director of industries, is a bit more serious—he is accused of fomenting enmity between brother IAS officers by creating religion-based WhatsApp groups, one called 'Hindu Mallu officers' and another tagged 'Muslim Mallu officers'.

The action against Prasanth took place after the ACS submitted a report to the government on a series of violations, including missing files during the former's previous term as special secretary, Backward Classes. On social media, Prasanth called Jayathilak a maverick "who spoiled the lives of junior officers" and chided him for being the "self-proclaimed next chief secretary" of the state. Jayathilak, a 1991 batch IAS officer, is the senior-most official serving in Kerala and certainly has a good chance of succeeding current CS Sarada Muraleedharan, who retires in April 2025. A combative Prasanth continued his tirade against Jayathilak even after receiving the suspension order and says he plans to move the Central Administrative Tribunal against his suspension, which accuses him of 'grave indiscipline' and 'undermining the public image of the administrative machinery'.





IAS officers N. Prasanth (left) and K. Gopalakrishnan have been suspended by the Kerala government for offences 'unbecoming of an officer borne in the cadre of the IAS'

"I acted as a whistleblower, but received a suspension order for telling the truth. I will try to get justice on every platform available for an ordinary citizen," Prasanth told INDIA TODAY. 'Collector bro', as he was known when he was Kozhikode district collector, has had a controversial run of late, especially during his stint as private secretary to the home minister (2014-16) when Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala occupied the chair. Opting to strike a perceptible contrast, his object of derision, Jayathilak, has taken the high ground. "I don't treat the officer's social media bullying as personal. I'm bound by the code of conduct of the service, I can't go beyond its brief," says the senior officer.

Meanwhile, Gopalakrishnan, a techie who had a stint in the US before joining the Kerala cadre has, according to one retired bureaucrat, "made a fool of himself". After he was outed by some of his colleagues in the WhatsApp faux pas, the IAS officer lodged a police complaint saying his mobile was hacked—except that he reformated his mobile a number of times before submitting it to the cyber cell. Investigations have found that the mobile was not hacked.

The controversy has added to the litany of disasters that have hounded the second Pinarayi Vijayan government. This isn't the first instance of its favoured civil servants going astray. In October, the CM had to remove additional DGP M.R. Ajithkumar from the coveted 'law and order' post after a series of controversies. "The state government and the CM seem to have no control over the bureaucracy. Now they are even suspending officers who were once close to the government," says Opposition leader V.D. Satheeshan of the Congress. ■